

ADVANCING FIRST CLASS PRE-K IN ALABAMA

Access 2026: Enrollment, Waitlists, and Where the Pressure Is

County enrollment and waitlist patterns (2024–25) and the first site-level look at sign-ups (November 2025)

JoonHo Lee and Alison Hooper ■ August 2026

This brief updates the series' access baseline with First Class Pre-K's 2024–25 county counts, and it adds the first analysis of the program's site-by-site waitlist sign-ups. In the county data, 24,238 of Alabama's 59,016 four-year-olds, or 41.1 percent, were enrolled and 5,243, or 8.9 percent, were waitlisted, while model-adjusted county enrollment shares run from about 19 to 93 percent. The site file changes how we read the waitlist itself: as of November 2025, its 7,523 site sign-ups traced back to 4,679 distinct children, because three in ten waitlisted children are signed up at more than one site. Although both sources describe access, they cover different program years, and we keep them in separate sections throughout.

Four findings organize this update, and we take them up in turn below:

- **Uneven coverage.** A child's county of residence is strongly associated with the likelihood of a First Class seat: model-adjusted enrollment shares range from about 19 percent in Shelby to 93 percent in Marengo (figure 1).
- **High-pressure counties.** Fourteen counties combine below-average enrollment with above-average waitlists (figure 2), led in absolute terms by Madison with 629 waitlisted children, Mobile with 604, and Shelby with 423. Seating the waitlisted children in those fourteen counties would take roughly 148 classrooms and would lift statewide enrollment from 41.1 to 45.6

percent, whereas clearing the full statewide waitlist, about 291 classrooms, would reach 50 percent.

- **Duplicate sign-ups.** Because 30.8 percent of waitlisted children are listed at two or more sites, and one at 16, the 7,523 site entries overstate the 4,679 distinct children waiting by about 60 percent (figure 3).
- **Concentration.** Waitlist pressure is concentrated in a minority of sites, since the median listed site has 7 sign-ups while the most oversubscribed has 216 and the top tenth of sites holds 42.5 percent of all entries (figure 4).

The counts are program administrative records, the shares depend on estimated four-year-old populations, and the waitlists record only families who signed up rather than all unmet demand; we return to these limits below.

Two Lenses on Access: Counties and Sites

Expansion planning has always run on county numbers, which identify the counties that enroll few children and wait many. Those numbers still matter, because they are how classrooms get budgeted, yet they obscure two features of access that we can now document. The first is uncertainty, since a small county's enrollment share may swing several percentage points on a handful of children, and we therefore report model-adjusted shares with credible intervals rather than treating every county's rate as equally well determined. The second is the site grain: families do not apply to counties but to sites, and the site-level file reveals both double-counting, in which the same child appears on several lists, and concentration, in which a few sites carry outsized queues. Although neither feature changes the statewide totals, both change what we mean by "the waitlist."

This brief, the ninth in the *Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama* series, updates the access analysis that opened the series (Hooper and Lee 2025).¹

BOX 1

Data and Methods

County counts. ADECE First Class Pre-K administrative counts for 2024–25: four-year-old population, enrollment, and waitlist for each of the 67 counties (59,016 / 24,238 / 5,243 statewide). Shares divide county counts by the county's estimated four-year-old population.

Model adjustment. County shares carry an empirical-Bayes adjustment, fitted across all 67 counties, that pulls small-county shares toward the typical county and attaches a 95 percent credible interval; raw counts are reported alongside. The same adjustment appears in the companion county profiles.

Site sign-ups. The program's waitlist file as of November 7, 2025 (2025–26 program year): one record per child-site sign-up, 7,523 records across 537 sites. Child identifiers were used only to count distinct children and multi-site listings, then discarded; no site-level queue is named in this brief.

Scenario arithmetic. Classroom counts divide waitlisted children by 18 (the program's standard classroom size). Scenarios are arithmetic, not siting plans. All results are descriptive.

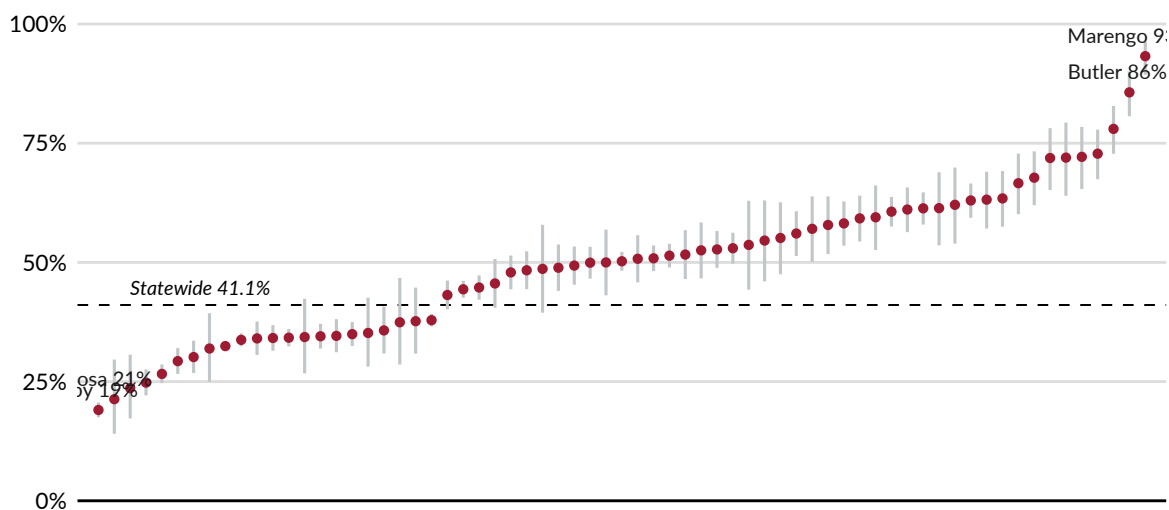
County Coverage and Its Uncertainty

Figure 1 arrays all 67 counties by model-adjusted enrollment share, and the spread is wide: Marengo, at 93 percent adjusted, and Butler, at 86, effectively enroll most of their four-year-olds, whereas Shelby, at 19, and Coosa, at 21, enroll about a fifth. Where a four-year-old lives is thus associated with a large difference in the chance of holding a First Class seat. The credible intervals matter as much as the point estimates, because for the largest counties the adjusted share is tightly determined, while for the smallest counties the data remain consistent with a wide range of underlying rates. We therefore read single-year rates in counties with one or two hundred four-year-olds as approximate, and small differences in rank may not be meaningful.

FIGURE 1

County Enrollment Shares Span a 74-Point Range

Model-adjusted share of four-year-olds enrolled, with 95 percent credible intervals, 67 counties, 2024–25



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K enrollment and waitlist counts, 2024–25.

Notes: ADECE = Alabama Department of Early Childhood Education. Counties ordered by adjusted share; whiskers are 95 percent credible intervals from an empirical-Bayes model fitted across all 67 counties. Dashed line marks the statewide (child-weighted) share.

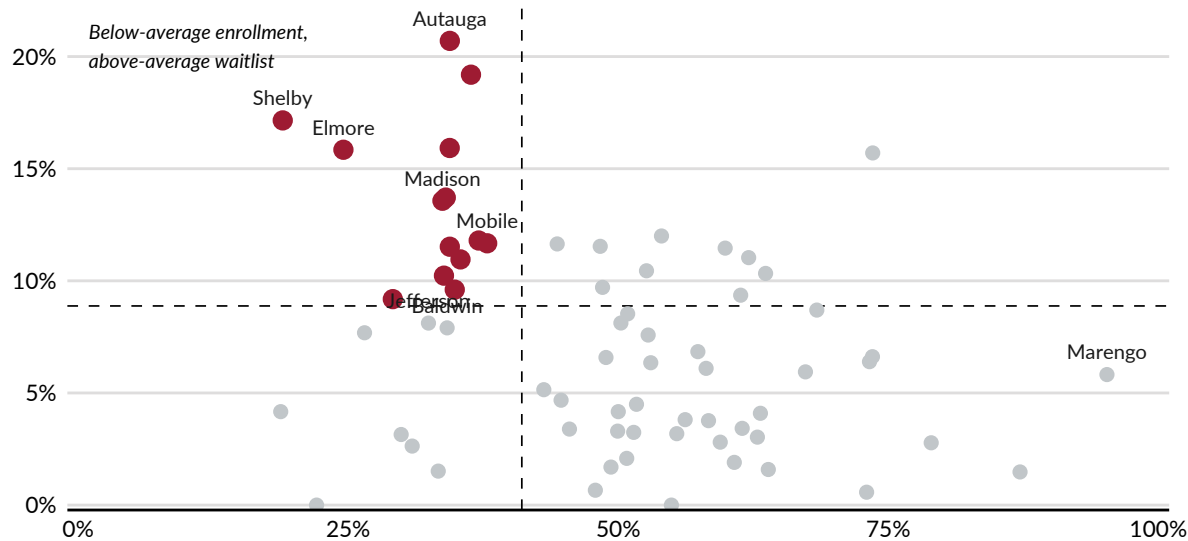
Counties Where Low Enrollment and Long Waitlists Coincide

Crossing the two county measures produces the pressure map in figure 2, in which fourteen counties fall into the high-pressure quadrant, with an enrollment share below the statewide 41.1 percent and a waitlist share above the statewide 8.9 percent. These are not small places: Madison, with 629 waitlisted children, Mobile, with 604, and Shelby, with 423, head the list (table 1), and the fourteen counties together hold 2,672 waitlisted children, just over half the statewide waitlist. In these counties a low enrollment share is associated with visible excess demand rather than with an absence of families seeking seats.

FIGURE 2

Below-Average Enrollment, Above-Average Waitlists: The High-Pressure Quadrant

Share of four-year-olds enrolled and share waitlisted, 67 counties, 2024–25



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K enrollment and waitlist counts, 2024–25.

Notes: Unadjusted shares; dashed lines mark statewide shares (41.1 and 8.9 percent). Crimson points are the 14 counties below the statewide enrollment share and above the statewide waitlist share.

TABLE 1

Madison, Mobile, and Shelby Lead the High-Pressure Counties

The 14 counties with below-average enrollment and above-average waitlist shares, 2024–25

County	4-year-olds	Enrolled (share)	Waitlisted	Waitlist share
Madison	4,635	1,563 (33.7%)	629	13.6%
Mobile	5,174	1,959 (37.9%)	604	11.7%
Shelby	2,466	467 (18.9%)	423	17.2%
Etowah	1,196	407 (34.0%)	164	13.7%
Elmore	953	234 (24.6%)	151	15.8%
Autauga	715	246 (34.4%)	148	20.7%
Limestone	1,276	439 (34.4%)	147	11.5%
Houston	1,374	479 (34.9%)	132	9.6%
Cullman	1,078	314 (29.1%)	99	9.2%
Dale	694	235 (33.9%)	71	10.2%
Marion	356	126 (35.4%)	39	11.0%
Lamar	157	54 (34.4%)	25	15.9%
Henry	178	66 (37.1%)	21	11.8%
Greene	99	36 (36.4%)	19	19.2%

Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K enrollment and waitlist counts, 2024–25.

Notes: Unadjusted counts and shares; sorted by waitlisted children.

Simple arithmetic gives that pressure a scale. Seating the 2,672 waitlisted children in these 14 counties would take roughly 148 classrooms and would lift statewide enrollment from 41.1 to 45.6 percent. Clearing the entire statewide waitlist—5,243 entries in the statewide count, or about 291 classrooms—would bring the state to 50 percent, meaning half of Alabama’s four-year-olds in First Class Pre-K. We report these figures as arithmetic scenarios rather than as siting plans, since they say nothing about where classrooms could actually be placed.

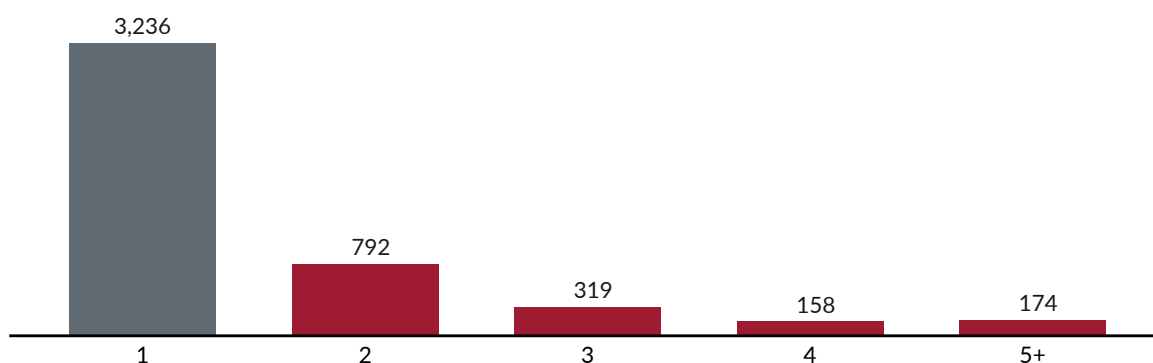
What the Site-Level Sign-Up File Shows

Although the county counts record each child once, the site-level sign-ups do not, because a family may add a child to more than one site’s list. As of November 2025, the program’s waitlist file held 7,523 site entries representing 4,679 distinct children, of whom about seven in ten, or 3,236, were listed at exactly one site. The remaining 30.8 percent were listed at two or more sites, with 792 at two, 319 at three, and one child at sixteen (figure 3). Multi-site listing therefore inflates the apparent size of the queue: any tally that sums site entries overstates the number of distinct waiting children by roughly 60 percent.

FIGURE 3

Three in Ten Waitlisted Children Are Signed Up at More Than One Site

Distinct waitlisted children, by number of sites listed, November 2025



Source: Authors' analysis of the ADECE First Class Pre-K site waitlist file, November 7, 2025.

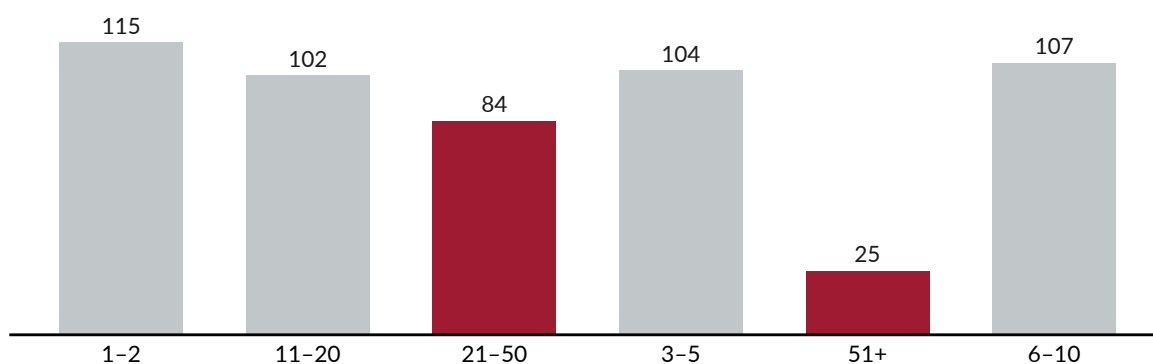
Notes: 4,679 distinct children across 7,523 child-site sign-ups (2025–26 program year).

The complement of duplication is concentration (figure 4). Half of the 537 listed sites have queues of 7 sign-ups or fewer, a level that likely reflects ordinary friction rather than shortage. Yet 109 sites carry more than 20 sign-ups each, the most oversubscribed carries 216, and the top tenth of sites holds 42.5 percent of all entries. Waitlist pressure is thus associated with particular buildings rather than with counties as a whole. The statewide waitlist is substantially an account of roughly a hundred specific locations at which demand appears to have outrun a single building's capacity, a distinction we cannot draw from the county file alone.

FIGURE 4

Most Site Queues Are Short; A Minority Are Very Long

Listed sites, by number of waitlist sign-ups, November 2025



Source: Authors' analysis of the ADECE First Class Pre-K site waitlist file, November 7, 2025.

Notes: 537 sites with at least one sign-up. Crimson bars mark sites with more than 20 sign-ups; individual sites are not named.

Discussion

The arithmetic assembled here makes one destination concrete: about 291 classrooms would seat every currently waitlisted child and would put half of Alabama’s four-year-olds in First Class Pre-K, while the 14-county core alone, at roughly 148 classrooms, would move the state 4.5 points. Because these remain arithmetic scenarios rather than siting plans, they size an opportunity without describing a route to it, and the facilities, staffing, and funding that any route would require fall outside what these data can address.

Our second implication concerns how the waitlist is counted. Because site sign-ups overstate distinct children by about 60 percent, expansion cases built on sums of site queues will overshoot the need. The program’s own child identifiers resolve the November file to 4,679 distinct children, and that is the figure to plan against whenever the starting point is a site queue rather than the statewide count. Reporting that figure routinely would likely improve the comparability of waitlist statistics from one year to the next.

Moreover, the site file may serve as a placement instrument. Roughly a hundred sites with queues above 20 constitute a revealed map of demand in which the need is documented and the addresses are known. Where those sites can add a classroom, expansion would meet families where they have already asked to be served, and where they cannot, the queue still marks the neighborhood in which to search. A siting analysis built on travel times, which is planned for this series, could take these queues as its demand anchor.

Finally, the uncertainty attached to small-county rates has practical consequences. Several policy-relevant rankings reshuffle within the credible intervals shown in figure 1, so county-level funding or targeting rules keyed to point estimates alone are likely to misclassify small counties in both directions.

Limitations

These analyses have several limitations. Waitlists undercount true unmet demand, because they record only families who found a list and signed up, while families deterred by distance, hours of operation, or simple unawareness never appear in them. The two data vintages also differ: the county counts are 2024–25 totals, whereas the site file is a November 2025 snapshot for the 2025–26 program year, and we therefore keep them in separate sections and never mix them in a single statistic. Population denominators are estimates, since county four-year-old counts are planning estimates, which is why shares above 100 percent are possible in small counties and why we report adjusted shares alongside the raw ones. The scenarios are also arithmetic: classroom counts assume the program’s standard 18-child classroom and say nothing about facilities, staffing, or funding, which are the subjects of the companion briefs on workforce and cost.

Notes

- ¹ The 2025 access brief targeted a broader set of 20 counties using that year's counts and a different targeting definition, yielding a scenario of roughly 229 classrooms. The scenarios reported here apply the rule stated in the text, namely a below-statewide enrollment share combined with an above-statewide waitlist share on 2024–25 counts, so the two briefs' scenario numbers are not directly comparable.

References

Hooper, Alison, and JoonHo Lee. 2025. "Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama—Brief 1: Expanding Access to First Class Pre-K." Tuscaloosa: University of Alabama, College of Education.

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ABOUT THIS PROJECT

The Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project examines First Class Pre-K funding, implementation, access, and comparisons with other state pre-K programs. Its goal is to offer recommendations for expanding First Class Pre-K while maintaining high levels of quality.

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